■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Friday, October 16, 2026

TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

THE LIST (5 stories)

■ *California principal admits to rigging student election to make child class president*

The Angle: *California principal admits to rigging student election to make child class president*

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://ktla.com/video/california-principal-admits-to-rigging-student-election-to-make-child-class-president/12263776/

■■ *Texas sued after glitch delays almost 600,000 voter registrations*

The Angle: *A software glitch in one of the biggest swing states just delayed voter registration for nearly 600,000 people - and now the state's getting sued over it. Voting access always lights up the phone lines, especially with an election on the horizon.*

- **Texas** is being sued over a system glitch tied to voter registration processing.
- Nearly **600,000** voter registrations were delayed because of the error.
- The lawsuit puts the state's election infrastructure under a public microscope right before voters need it most.

The Debate Starter

- If a glitch can stall 600,000 registrations, how much do you actually trust the system counting your vote?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2026/oct/15/texas-glitch-delay-voter-registrations

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🛩■ *Lockheed Martin Showered Susan Collins With Cash as F-35 Program Hit Turbulence. Collins received tens of thousands from Lockheed during a two-month period surrounding a critical 2023 watchdog report.*

The Angle: *A defense giant ramped up donations to a sitting U.S. Senator at the exact moment a government watchdog was torching its biggest fighter jet program — the kind of timing that writes its own punchline about how Washington really works.*

- **Lockheed Martin** sent **tens of thousands of dollars** to Senator **Susan Collins**
- The money flowed during a **two-month window** in **2023**
- That window lines up with a **critical watchdog report** on the **F-35 program**
- **Susan Collins** sits on committees with direct influence over defense spending and oversight

The Debate Starter

- Is this just how lobbying works, or does the timing here cross a line?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://theintercept.com/2026/10/15/susan-collins-lockheed-martin-f35-fighter-jet/

■■ *U.S. 'monitoring' Canada for signs of midterm election interference, ambassador says*

The Angle: *This flips the usual election-interference story on its head — instead of worrying about foreign meddling in a U.S. vote, the U.S. ambassador is publicly saying they're keeping an eye on an ally, which is awkward timing for U.S.-Canada relations right before the midterms.*

- The **U.S. ambassador** says Washington is actively **'monitoring' Canada** for any signs of interference in the **U.S. midterm elections**.
- It's a notable role reversal — usually it's foreign adversaries getting accused of meddling in U.S. elections, not a close ally like **Canada**.

The Debate Starter

- Does it seem backwards that the U.S. is worried about Canada — one of its closest allies — messing with an American election?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/hoekstra-watching-canada-election-interference-9.7380834

■ *Talk grows that China is routing US Treasury holdings through Canada: Bloomberg*

The Angle: *Bloomberg says chatter is heating up that China is quietly routing its US Treasury purchases through Canada - a possible financial workaround amid US-China tension that pulls Canada into the middle of a superpower money game.*

- **Bloomberg** is reporting growing speculation that **China** may be channeling some of its **US Treasury** holdings **through Canada**
- The theory: using Canada as a go-between could let **China** keep buying US debt while sidestepping direct US-China friction
- No official confirmation yet - this is still being treated as market chatter, not a confirmed policy move

The Debate Starter

- If true, is Canada playing peacemaker middleman here, or getting used as cover in a US-China money chess match?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://investinglive.com/news/talk-grows-that-china-is-routing-us-treasury-holdings-through-canada-bloomberg/

Backup options:

■ *“The US has no discipline, no strategy, no patience”: Chrystia Freeland on Canada’s place in the new world order*

The Angle: *Chrystia Freeland, one of Canada's best-known political heavyweights, just took a direct shot at American leadership and challenged Canada to rethink its whole strategy in a shifting global order - that's the kind of blunt, high-profile jab that gets cross-border chatter going fast.*

- **Chrystia Freeland** - Canada's former Deputy PM and Finance Minister - says the **US** has "**no discipline, no strategy, no patience**"
- The comments frame a bigger question: where does **Canada** fit as the old US-led world order shifts

The Debate Starter

- Is Freeland calling it straight on the US losing its grip, or is this just Canadian frustration spilling into the open?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL:
https://torontolife.com/city/the-us-has-no-discipline-no-strategy-no-patience-chrystia-freeland-on-canadas-place-in-the-new-world-order/

■■ *Comcast Donated $7.5 Million for Donald Trump’s Lavish New White House Ballroom*

The Angle: *A major media/telecom giant bankrolling a lavish new wing of the White House is exactly the kind of money-meets-politics story that gets people talking about optics, favors, and who's really footing the bill.*

- **Comcast** reportedly donated **$7.5 million** toward the project.
- The money is going toward a new, **lavish ballroom** being built at the **White House**.
- The project is tied directly to **President Donald Trump**.

The Debate Starter

- Is a corporation funding a White House renovation a nice gesture or a flashing-red conflict-of-interest sign?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/tv/news/comcast-funding-trump-white-house-ballroom-1236913205/

■■ *Trudeau government advised it would be expected to carry out ICC arrest warrants, including for Netanyahu*

The Angle: *A leaked memo shows Trudeau's government knew it could be legally on the hook to detain a sitting world leader if he ever set foot in Canada - that's the kind of diplomatic landmine that makes for a real debate.*

- Internal memo warned **Justin Trudeau's** government it was expected to carry out **ICC arrest warrants**
- Warrants named **Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu**, his then-defence minister, and **Hamas leaders**
- Memo came while an ICC prosecutor was still preparing the warrants, before they were formally issued
- Raises the question of whether Canada would actually detain an allied head of government on its soil

The Debate Starter

- If Netanyahu landed in Toronto tomorrow, should Canada actually arrest him - or is that a bridge too far for an ally?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/icc-arrest-warrants-canada-9.7380532?cmp=rss

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■ *EU debates Ukraine funding, as Zelenskyy's relations with the Trump administration ebb again*

The Angle: *This is a real split-screen moment — European leaders closing ranks around Zelenskyy at a summit while Trump publicly slams Ukraine's own battlefield tactics, raising fresh doubts about how solid U.S. backing really is.*

- **EU leaders** rallied around **Volodymyr Zelenskyy** at a summit on **Friday**
- **Donald Trump** blasted Ukraine's strikes on **Russian oil refineries**, calling them a **"disgrace"**
- The comments mark another cooling point in **Trump-Zelenskyy relations**, which have swung hot and cold throughout the war

The Debate Starter

- Is Trump right that hitting Russian refineries crosses a line, or is this the U.S. second-guessing an ally fighting for its survival?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/eu-summit-ukraine-russia-war-9.7383053?cmp=rss

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■ *New White House press secretary Katie Zacharia didn't pass the bar exam*

The Angle: *The President's new chief spokesperson is already getting grilled over her legal credentials days into the job, and how she handled the questions on camera is becoming its own story.*

- **Katie Zacharia** is the new **White House press secretary**
- She's had to publicly defend her **legal background** this week
- Report says she **never passed the bar exam**
- Her first official briefing was notably **cut short**

The Debate Starter

- Does it actually matter if a press secretary isn't a licensed lawyer, or is this just a gotcha story?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/katie-zacharia-interview-press-secretary-role-9.7382401?cmp=rss

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CANADIAN NEWS (4 stories)

■■ *Ambassador Hoekstra warns Canadians not to meddle in midterms but also to accept blame for costing Republicans the midterms*

The Angle: *The U.S. Ambassador to Canada is reportedly telling Canadians to butt out of American politics while simultaneously pinning blame on them for costing Republicans the midterms - a head-scratching contradiction that's already lighting up Canadian social media.*

- **Ambassador Pete Hoekstra** is warning **Canadians** not to meddle in the **U.S. midterms**.
- In the same breath, he's blaming **Canada** for costing **Republicans** the midterms.
- The mixed message is making the rounds on **r/canada**, with users quick to call out the irony.

The Debate Starter

- Can you really blame Canada for a U.S. election while also telling it to stay out of U.S. elections?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.thebeaverton.com/2026/10/ambassador-hoekstra-warns-canadians-not-to-meddle-in-midterms-but-also-to-accept-blame-for-costing-republicans-the-midterms/

■■ *Carney says Albertans should vote 'No to the Nine' in referendum*

The Angle: *A sitting Prime Minister publicly telling one province how to vote on its own referendum is a big, unusual move - it's federal politics crashing straight into Alberta's independence-vibe tensions, and that's instant hosts-take-sides material.*

- Prime Minister **Mark Carney** is urging Albertans to vote **'No to the Nine'** in the upcoming referendum.
- The comment puts **Carney** directly at odds with whatever's driving the Alberta referendum push - a rare federal leader wading into provincial ballot politics.

The Debate Starter

- Should the Prime Minister even be weighing in on a provincial referendum, or does that just prove Alberta's point about Ottawa overreach?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/calgary/mark-carney-no-to-the-nine-alberta-referendum-9.7382226

■■ *Danielle Smith has said no to a second referendum. But that decision might not be hers to make*

The Angle: *Alberta's independence talk just got a constitutional twist: the Premier can say 'no referendum' all she wants, but if this is citizen-driven, the public might be able to force the vote anyway. That's a juicy political standoff for hosts to dig into.*

- **Danielle Smith** has publicly shut the door on a second referendum on Alberta separation.
- The catch: the decision on whether a vote happens **may not actually be hers to make**.
- Alberta's citizen-initiated referendum rules could let the public force the question back onto the ballot over the **Premier's** objection.

The Debate Starter

- Should everyday Albertans be able to force a separation vote even if their own Premier says no?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/calgary/danielle-smith-has-said-no-to-a-second-referendum-but-that-decision-might-not-be-hers-to-make-9.7382664?cmp=rss

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■ *Nathan Fielder's You Can See Everything gazes into the abyss of Elizabeth Holmes*

The Angle: *The guy behind "The Rehearsal" and "Nathan For You" just turned his lens on Theranos fraudster Elizabeth Holmes — and critics are saying the weirder the approach, the less knowable she actually becomes.*

- The doc is called **"You Can See Everything"** — from **Nathan Fielder**
- It centers on **Elizabeth Holmes**, the **Theranos** founder jailed for defrauding investors
- **CBC** calls Fielder's approach **"genuinely unparalleled"** in originality
- The takeaway: the more footage you gather on someone this guarded, **the less you actually know**

The Debate Starter

- Can any documentary actually crack a person as controlled and media-trained as Elizabeth Holmes, or does more footage just mean more performance?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/entertainment/you-can-see-everything-review-9.7382874?cmp=rss

Backup options:

■ *Think you'll win the $90M Lotto Max? Here's a primer on your odds*

The Angle: *Friday's Lotto Max draw is the richest prize ever up for grabs in Canada, and nothing gets a radio audience daydreaming faster than a nine-figure jackpot and brutal odds.*

- Friday's draw is for **$90 million** — the **largest lottery jackpot ever available to win in Canada**.
- CBC breaks down the actual **odds of winning** the top prize.
- The jackpot is being compared against **past Lotto Max prizes** to show just how historic this one is.

The Phone-In Trigger

- Call in: what's the first thing you'd buy if you won $90 million tomorrow?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/lotto-max-prize-9.7381723?cmp=rss

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■ *LIVE3 Digital Channel*

The Angle: *A new digital channel popping up from CTV News is the kind of low-key media shakeup that's easy to miss but worth a quick mention for anyone tracking how Canadians are getting their news these days.*

The Quick Take

- Streaming news channels keep multiplying - are you actually following any of them, or just sticking with the apps you already have?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMidkFVX3lxTFBnanZ5RWRhZGJlaHRHbUJYdjVKUHAzeHJuSHF1UDE5RGZ4QVRKU2lZVklBYVdySnA1N1lVMUtwMnJWR1VfT2I4S3FRbGotTVhrd0g3Ml9HUF9XQzh1Y3JiUWlXeHVFVXNDMDhWYVdaLXc3NnE3eFE?oc=5

■■ *Flintstones vitamins, Aleve and Claritin recalled over distribution error*

The Angle: *These are three of the most common household names in Canadian medicine cabinets, so this isn't some obscure recall - it's the stuff parents and anyone with a cold or allergies probably has sitting at home right now.*

- The recall covers **Flintstones children's vitamins**, **Aleve**, and **Claritin** - three very common household products.
- The cause is described as a **distribution error**, not a contamination or safety defect found in the product itself.
- Health officials are urging Canadians to check their own bottles against the recall details.

The Medicine Cabinet Check

- Go check right now - do you have any of these three bottles sitting in your house today?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMisAFBVV95cUxOelRmLVNhUHI2Qlh5WThoVy1ydmRsZmZXRklsTHNlenktZDFnSTVGaTFVQzNmM016MVBhVjB6NkQ0U2pVdGlvSktTS3RmUmU0U3FvSmRHZ2NjZlJueTRVc1ktRmtiSEF4NWtEWHJQMkhEWVZZY1RnaXdOdkRQM3AwandzUC04QmFhUE40MFNCRGhZNk1kbHJRX2Y5c1ZVMW5HVFRHU1pvRzRRaGhaVTRNRA?oc=5

■ *B.C. business owner loses NEXUS privileges after $20 border fee mistake*

The Angle: *It's the ultimate 'the system is insane' story for anyone who's ever dealt with border bureaucracy - a B.C. business owner lost their trusted-traveler NEXUS status over a tiny $20 fee slip-up, and that hits home for every Canadian who crosses the border for work or shopping.*

- A **B.C. business owner** had their **NEXUS card privileges revoked**
- The trigger was reportedly a **$20 border fee mistake**
- NEXUS status, once pulled, is notoriously hard to get back

The Phone-In Trigger

- Have you ever lost a privilege - NEXUS, a loyalty status, a membership - over a mistake way smaller than the punishment?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMirwFBVV95cUxPMXF1SzV0cXdHTUV4VjFkeVdYNDJzbEZQR01YS2hJMURSZW5JY25QcE1mN2NUUHo2VmRMTUk0eXVENDBHVHZjNm5ta2tsa1FFOHQ0dU9aTWp6b0VwTDJjS1Vib2dOYlZYN0dTeF9Ec1h2YlllNTQ2eUxnWW01WE9WLWRrRGthR05nWjV2cWtFVnZyMHpiUF9FNk9jNldwOWNkMy1VM19mbTJQZFBrRURJ?oc=5

ENTERTAINMENT (5 stories)

■ *Anna Faris responds to Chuck Lorre saying she wasn't right choice for 'Mom': "Yikes. Yes, I read a few things. I really didn't see that coming. Of course it hurts.*

The Angle: *A seven-year sitcom star just found out her old boss publicly doubted casting her — and her classy-but-wounded response, paired with a sobriety reveal, is the kind of real-talk moment that gets people buzzing.*

- **Anna Faris** responded directly to **Chuck Lorre**'s comments questioning whether she was the right choice for **'Mom'**
- Her reaction: **"Yikes. Yes, I read a few things. I really didn't see that coming. Of course it hurts."**
- She says she's **"proud of what we made together"** and never took a day of the 7-year run for granted
- She also revealed she's been **sober for a year and a half**, saying **"I'm healthy, I'm working, and I'm happier than I've been in a long time"**

The Debate Starter

- Is it ever okay for a boss to publicly second-guess casting you years after the show ends — even if they still praise your work?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://i.redd.it/essxf9rvtqvh1.jpeg

■ *Lori Loughlin's ex Mossimo Giannulli makes surprising spousal support request in divorce response*

The Angle: *Lori Loughlin and Mossimo Giannulli's split already had Hollywood buzzing, and now his formal response is adding a twist nobody saw coming — spousal support.*

- **Lori Loughlin** filed her divorce petition asking to split assets, property and debts per their **prenuptial agreement**.
- **Mossimo Giannulli's** response reportedly includes a **spousal support request** — a surprise given the prenup angle.
- The two have been married since **1997** and weathered the **Varsity Blues** scandal together before this split.

The Debate Starter

- If you've got a prenup, should spousal support even be on the table — or is Mossimo's move a bold legal gamble?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/10/16/celebrity-news/mossimo-giannulli-makes-surprising-spousal-support-request-in-lori-loughlin-divorce-response/

■ *'I Know It's Coming': Kate Zacharia Says She Expects ‘SNL’ To Mock Her White House Briefing*

The Angle: *A White House staffer calling her own 'SNL' takedown before it even airs is a fun role-reversal — it's the ultimate sign a moment has gone viral, and it opens up a debate on whether politicians should just lean into getting mocked.*

- **Kate Zacharia** says about an 'SNL' sketch mocking her White House briefing: **"I know it's coming."**
- She's publicly predicting the parody before it's even aired.

The Debate Starter

- Is it smarter for public figures to laugh along with their own 'SNL' roast, or does acknowledging it just invite more?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.huffpost.com/entry/katie-zacharia-snl-mockery_n_6ad13df7e4b0bfd25656bc0e

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■ *Sydney Sweeney Ad Under Fire as Dodgers Star Slams 'Soft Porn' MLB Ads: 'My Son Wants To Watch Baseball'*

The Angle: *A pro athlete publicly trashing his own league's ad campaign is rare — and dragging Sydney Sweeney into a 'soft porn' debate about family-friendly baseball is exactly the kind of culture-clash story that gets phones ringing.*

- A **Dodgers star** publicly blasted an **MLB ad** featuring **Sydney Sweeney**, calling it **'soft porn.'**
- His stated issue: **'My son wants to watch baseball'** — framing it as a family-viewing problem, not just a style complaint.
- The ad has become a flashpoint over how MLB markets itself and who the league is trying to attract.

The Debate Starter

- Is this legit family-friendly concern, or is a baseball player just not the one who gets to set the dress code for ads?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.medicaldaily.co.uk/alex-call-mlb-soft-porn-ads-playoff-broadcasts-1759543

■ *House Press Secretary Katie Zacharia Didn’t Pass Bar Exam*

The Angle: *A political aide getting outed for flunking the bar exam is exactly the kind of petty-but-juicy gotcha that blows up on social media, especially when it's a public-facing spokesperson whose job is managing other people's image.*

- The story centers on **Katie Zacharia**, identified as a **House Press Secretary**
- The claim making rounds: she **did not pass the bar exam**
- Surfaced via **r/fauxmoi**, a sub known for digging up receipts on public figures

The Side-Eye Starter

- Does a failed bar exam actually matter if the job was never about practicing law in the first place?

Reddit r/fauxmoi (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://i.redd.it/og6ukb295nvh1.png

Backup options:

■ *Do we really need another Sense and Sensibility movie?*

The Angle: *Yet another Jane Austen adaptation is hitting screens, and this one's leaning hard into the sisterly bond between Elinor and Marianne instead of just the romance — a good excuse to ask why Hollywood keeps going back to this well.*

- New take on **Sense and Sensibility** puts the **Elinor and Marianne Dashwood** sibling relationship front and center
- Filmed with a grounded, naturalistic style using real **landscapes** rather than glossy period-drama polish
- Reviewed by **CBC**, framing it as a fresh spin on the **Jane Austen** classic

The Debate Starter

- Is there such a thing as "too many" adaptations of a classic, or does every generation deserve its own Austen?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/entertainment/sense-and-sensibility-sisters-remake-jane-austen-9.7375202?cmp=rss

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■ *Wyatt Flores answers questions about his new album ‘Scared of Heights’ in Confession Cube*

The Angle: *Country's buzziest new voice just dropped an album called 'Scared of Heights' and got locked in Page Six's Confession Cube to answer whatever fans threw at him - instant easy listening for anyone into country or just loves a good 'getting grilled on camera' moment.*

- New album is called **"Scared of Heights"**
- He opens up about a creative shift pulling in **early-2000s rock influences**
- Flores describes going through a self-proclaimed **"sexy song" era** on the record
- He got caught off guard by a surprise during the segment

The Debate Starter

- If you got locked in a 'Confession Cube,' what question would actually make you sweat?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/video/wyatt-flores-answers-questions-about-his-new-album-scared-of-heights-in-confession-cube/

■ *Kroi Talks New Song ‘SPIN’ & the Creative Journey Intersecting With the Chaos of ‘JoJo’*

The Angle: *Kroi's dropping new music but teasing behind-the-scenes chaos around their song 'JoJo' is the kind of 'wait, what happened?' tease that gets fans (and casual listeners) curious enough to dig in.*

- **Kroi** is talking about their new song **'SPIN'**
- The band also addresses the creative journey and "chaos" tied to their track **'JoJo'**
- Interview comes via **Billboard**

The Curiosity Hook

- What's messier: making the song, or living through what inspired it?

X/Twitter @Billboard (Tier 1) | Score: 76/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 19 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/billboard/status/2110974346185314807

■ *YOSHIKI Reflects on Music, Life, Legacy & His New Collaboration ‘Forever Love (Live)’ With Josh Groban: Interview*

The Angle: *Yoshiki's a legendary rock drummer/composer from X Japan, Groban's the ultimate smooth balladeer — this genre-mashup duet and legacy interview is a fun odd-couple collab story for music fans.*

The Odd-Couple Collab

- What's the most unexpected musical pairing you've ever actually loved?

X/Twitter @Billboard (Tier 1) | Score: 76/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 19 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/billboard/status/2110944137985880571

■ *‘The Batman Part II’ Production Is Back on, With Steven Soderbergh’s Help*

The Angle: *Matt Reeves is stepping away from the Batman sequel to deal with a family matter, and instead of shutting production down, they're bringing in Steven Soderbergh to finish shooting - a huge vote of confidence from one Oscar winner to another.*

- **Steven Soderbergh** is stepping in to complete principal photography on **'The Batman Part II'**
- Director **Matt Reeves** is stepping back temporarily to handle a **family matter**
- Production is officially back up and running after the pause

The Watercooler Take

- Soderbergh finishing someone else's superhero movie is like a Michelin chef covering a shift at your favorite diner - does that make you more or less excited for the movie?

gizmodo.com (Tier 2) | Score: 74/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://gizmodo.com/the-batman-part-ii-production-is-back-on-with-steven-soderberghs-help-2000826723

TRENDING TODAY

■ *Hilary Duff flaunts figure in yellow swimsuit on girls' trip as 'toxic mom group' drama resurfaces*

The Angle: *A sunny girls' trip photo shouldn't be controversial, but it's dragging the Ashley Tisdale 'toxic mom clique' drama right back into the spotlight — classic celebrity-world pettiness that's an easy, fun tangent for listeners.*

- **Hilary Duff** posted photos from a **Mexico girls' trip** rocking a **yellow swimsuit**.
- **Mandy Moore** was along for the trip, which is what reignited chatter.
- The drama ties back to the **Ashley Tisdale** 'toxic mom group' controversy that first blew up **earlier this year**.

The Debate Starter

- Are 'mom group' feuds actually toxic, or is this just manufactured celebrity drama we can't stop clicking on?

pagesix.com (Tier 2) | Score: 74/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/10/16/entertainment/hilary-duff-flaunts-figure-in-yellow-swimsuit-on-girls-trip-as-toxic-mom-group-drama-resurfaces/

Backup options:

■ *Social Security's 2027 COLA is the biggest since 2023. How it affects your payments. - Yahoo*

The Angle: *Social Security's 2027 cost-of-living adjustment is the largest increase since 2023, and it directly moves the monthly check for tens of millions of Americans - that's a kitchen-table story in basically every household with a retiree in it.*

- The **2027 Social Security COLA** is the biggest increase since **2023**.
- It changes the **monthly payment** for every current Social Security recipient, not just new filers.
- COLA bumps are meant to track inflation - so the size of the raise says something about how expensive things have gotten.

The Wallet Check

- Call in: has a COLA raise ever actually kept pace with your bills, or does it get eaten by rent and groceries before it even hits the account?

Google News (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 73/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 16 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMizwFBVV95cUxQTjZUd0VoLVVpZFVBMTZYT1ZWbjk0UWZGcng4bDhXX21Vbm5NaUprbjhadGx0TGNuTnM3YU5jMVRqaHBlUVprX24wZDNNelEyVjJFNkdBbTFLY0hOdG9BVTVKQzNnZ1U2Y3d4ZVF1bWQtUHdyNmwtSHl4VzNCODdJMkpXeHZ4VlAzby1kbzFoWWFwU19TWEcxNjByejRGV1hMdVlwcVcwVGpNVTFxb1NXVE9BVVZWOGlHUnlGSUdqTjBfYldGREw4R0E2dFc2M1U?oc=5

LIFESTYLE CHAT

■ *Chips, cereals and frozen meals could raise risk of brain damage and dementia, study finds*

The Angle: *A new study links everyday staples like chips, cereal, and frozen meals to higher dementia and brain damage risk - which hits different because almost everyone in the audience has these exact items in their*

pantry right now.

- The study flags common **ultra-processed foods** - think **chips, cereal, and frozen meals** - as a possible risk factor.
- Researchers are tying these everyday staples to higher risk of **brain damage** and **dementia** down the line.
- The foods named aren't niche junk food - they're pantry basics most households already have stocked.

The Pantry Check

- Be honest - how many of these three things are in your kitchen right now?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMixgFBVV95cUxQeElleXc2a29tZmFjVGtDQkxoeVkwN0RleW5jME9CX01CaE5rWVZaMzgyWEJHWkVlYTFnOENORDVRaE84WFMwWkVHc1BIaTE1dHNLdXZvWE9EUHBhMk54clg0blR4VXZiMzRyWElxaXg5S3ZQSEEzZVNodHc5Szd2aVVncXZQQzFsdzY5WXhlTnA2TVZmcUdyMVZVN3lLZEh4UUFrMXc4SHpfMWMydURKaG1oVkx2SmM1a3hSMFB4U0x0aHp5Q3c?oc=5

Backup options:

■ ***Nine in ten research papers disputing definition of ultraprocessed foods have industry ties.***

The Angle: *Everyone's been side-eyeing their grocery cart since 'ultraprocessed food' became a buzzword — but new research suggests a lot of the pushback against that very label is coming from people with skin in the game.*

- A new look at the science finds roughly **9 in 10** research papers that argue against or dispute the definition of 'ultraprocessed foods' have **ties to the food industry**
- The term 'ultraprocessed food' has exploded in health conversations over the last few years, tied to studies on obesity, heart disease, and overall diet quality
- The debate boils down to: is the ultraprocessed category based on solid science, or is it getting muddied by groups with a financial interest in keeping their products off the 'bad' list?

The Debate Starter

- Does it change how you feel about 'ultraprocessed' warnings when you hear the pushback studies are industry-funded?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.theexamination.org/articles/nova-ultraprocessed-foods-industry-ties-study

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■ ***A study of over 12,000 Norwegian families found that by age eight, a child's ADHD traits come mainly from their own genes, not from how their parents' genes shape the home. Researchers found no firm evidence that parenting style or the home environment tied to parents' DNA drives ADHD in their kids.***

The Angle: *This is the kind of study that lets parents exhale — new genetics research pushes back hard on the old 'bad parenting' narrative around ADHD, and that's a nerve every parent listening has touched.*

- Researchers tracked **over 12,000 Norwegian families** to figure out what really drives ADHD in kids.
- By age **8**, a child's ADHD traits were traced mainly to their **own genes** — not the home they grew up in.
- The study found **no firm evidence** that parenting style or home environment, even when linked to the parents' DNA, was driving the ADHD.
- Bottom line: it's looking a lot less like 'nurture' and a lot more like **nature**.

The Guilt-Trip Buster

- Phone lines open: if science clears the parenting, does that change how you talk about your kid's ADHD at the dinner table?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.psypost.org/child-s-own-genetics-drive-adhd-traits-more-than-family-environment-large-study/

CLOSER: THE KICKER/GOODBYES (franchise fallback)

■ *A simple change could make wind power safer for wildlife. At South Africa's Hopefield wind farm, painting two red stripes on one blade of four turbines was linked to an estimated median 83% reduction in bird deaths over 32 months, offering a way to protect birds while generating clean energy*

The Angle: *It's the ultimate good-news crossover story — clean energy AND wildlife protection, solved with literal paint. A tiny, cheap fix that makes a feel-good story even better.*

- Location: **Hopefield wind farm**, **South Africa**
- The fix: painting **two red stripes** on just **one blade** on each of **four turbines**
- The result: an estimated median **83% reduction** in bird deaths
- Timeframe: tracked over **32 months**

The Feel-Good Takeaway

- A can of paint might be the cheapest wildlife-conservation tool on the planet.

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.ecoticias.com/en/a-wind-farm-in-hopefield-south-africa-painted-two-red-stripes-on-one-blade-of-four-turbines-and-a-preprint-not-yet-peer-reviewed-estimates-bird-deaths-at-those-turbines-fell-a-median-83-percent/52043/

Backup options:

■ *In 2011, Taylor Swift donated 6,000 books worth $68,000 to a Pennsylvania library that was struggling to stay open; 15 years later, it circulated 182,228 items and drew 27,452 program participants in 2025*

The Angle: *A small-town Pennsylvania library was on the brink until Taylor Swift quietly bankrolled it — now, over a decade later, the place is absolutely thriving. It's the kind of full-circle, feel-good payoff story that's perfect to send listeners into their weekend on.*

- Back in **2011**, **Taylor Swift** donated **6,000 books** worth **$68,000** to a struggling Pennsylvania library.
- The donation reportedly helped keep the library's doors open.
- Fast forward to **2025**: that same library circulated **182,228 items** in one year.
- The library also drew **27,452 program participants** in 2025.

The Feel-Good Finish

- One pop star's book donation turned into a community institution — what's a small gesture you've seen pay off bigger than anyone expected?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/world/us/in-2011-taylor-swift-donated-6000-books-worth-68000-to-a-pennsylvania-library-that-was-struggling-to-stay-open-15-years-later-it-circulated-182228-items-and-drew-27452-program-participants-in-2025/amp_articleshow/134976044.cms

FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 0/5 this month; TECH TALK 4/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 3/3 this month)

(no flex-slot candidates cleared the cap/score bar today)

ADDITIONAL CANDIDATES (no specific segment match, but scored well on source/quality - producer's call on where these fit)

■■ *White House press secretary Katie Zacharia confirms she never passed bar exam after saying she's a lawyer*

The Angle: *She told reporters she's an attorney — turns out she never actually passed the bar. It's the kind of easily-checkable lie that makes you wonder why anyone thought it wouldn't surface.*

- **Katie Zacharia**, a **White House press secretary**, had claimed to be a lawyer
- She's now confirmed she **never passed the bar exam**
- Story surfaced via **r/nottheonion** — internet's shorthand for 'this is real, not satire'

The Easy Lie Detector

- Bar exam results are basically public record — why fib about something that's one search away from busted?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbsnews.com/news/white-house-press-secretary-katie-zacharia-lawyer-no-bar-exam/

■ *Rudy Giuliani’s Legal Defense Fund Isn’t Spending on Legal Expenses*

The Angle: *A fund literally named for legal expenses that isn't going toward legal expenses is the kind of irony that writes its own punchline - perfect button for the show.*

- The fund is branded as **Rudy Giuliani's legal defense fund**
- Reports flag that the money **isn't actually going toward his legal expenses**

The Easy Button

- Ask: if you set up a fund with a very specific name, shouldn't the money... go to that specific thing?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.washingtonsun.com/influence/rudy-giuliani-defense-fund-fundraising

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■ *Halo: Combat Evolved Gets A Nintendo 64 Multiplayer Port*

The Angle: *This landed on r/nottheonion for a reason — modders squeezing a 2001 Xbox shooter onto hardware that's over a decade older is the kind of 'wait, how is that even possible' story that's tailor-made for a quick goodbye-segment laugh.*

- **Halo: Combat Evolved** debuted on the **original Xbox** back in 2001.
- Modders are apparently squeezing a playable multiplayer version onto the **Nintendo 64** — a console that came out years before Halo did.
- The story's making rounds via **r/nottheonion**, Reddit's running list of real headlines that sound made up.

The Debate Starter

- Ask listeners: what's the most insane retro-console hack or mod they've ever seen pulled off?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://retrododo.com/halo-combat-evolved-gets-a-nintendo-64-multiplayer-port/

■ *Accenture Tells Employees They Can Now Spend Only $29 on Claude Per Month*

The Angle: *One of the world's biggest consulting firms is now rationing how much its own employees can spend on AI chatbot use - a sign companies that pushed everyone to use AI are suddenly watching the bill like hawks.*

- **Accenture** is reportedly telling staff they can spend no more than **$29 per month** on **Anthropic's Claude** assistant.
- It's a notable reversal in tone: AI tools get rolled out company-wide as a productivity win, then quietly get a spending cap once the invoices add up.
- Accenture is one of the largest professional services firms on the planet, so a policy like this at that scale tends to ripple into how other big employers think about AI budgets.

The Debate Starter

- If your office put a monthly dollar cap on your AI use, would that change how - or how often - you'd actually use it?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.404media.co/accenture-tells-employees-they-can-now-spend-only-29-on-claude-per-month/

■■ *X purges 13,000 accounts linked to suspected meddling ahead of US midterms*

The Angle: *A major platform wiping out thousands of accounts tied to suspected election meddling days before the US midterms is the kind of story that taps right into the bigger fear everyone has about trusting what they see online during election season.*

- **X** purged **13,000 accounts** flagged for suspected election meddling
- The sweep lands right ahead of the **US midterms**
- The company is framing it as a crackdown on coordinated manipulation on the platform

The Debate Starter

- Do you actually trust these platforms to catch election manipulation, or does this feel like a PR move timed for the headlines?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL:
https://www.theregister.com/security/2026/10/15/x-purges-13000-accounts-linked-to-suspected-meddling-ahead-of-us-midterms/5303234

BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

■ *Glasgow great-great-grandmother, 104, meets her brother again after 60 years apart. Susan Gair of Pollok turned 104 this summer. Her brother William, 86, moved to London about 60 years ago and the two lost touch. His daughter found an old article about Susan's 100th birthday.*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): The specific, almost cinematic detail (104 years old, 60 years apart, reunited with a 86-year-old brother) gives it a shareable emotional hook beyond the average reunion story.
The Angle: *A great-great-grandmother in Glasgow just hugged her little brother for the first time in six decades — and it only happened because his daughter stumbled on an old birthday article online. Pure, no-catch feel-good story to close the show on.*

- **Susan Gair** of Pollok, Glasgow turned **104** this summer
- Her brother **William**, **86**, moved to **London** about **60 years ago** and they lost touch
- William's daughter found an old article covering **Susan's 100th birthday** and tracked her down
- The siblings have now reunited in person after six decades apart

The Tissue Alert

- Ask listeners: is there a family member you've lost touch with that this story makes you want to track down?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://sheets.works/story/a-sunday-roast-in-leeds?r=stories

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■ *Woman arrested after blocking delivery robot in Center City Philadelphia confrontation*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Taps directly into the live culture-war backlash against delivery robots in public spaces, giving it built-in controversy and debate fuel.
The Angle: *A human-vs-machine street standoff in Center City Philly that's tailor-made for viral, 'you can't make this up' social shares — and it taps right into the bigger cultural anxiety about robots taking over sidewalks.*

- A **woman** was arrested in **Center City, Philadelphia** after a confrontation with a **delivery robot**.
- Police say she allegedly **blocked the robot** from moving, turning a sidewalk encounter into an arrest.
- The story's blowing up on **Reddit's r/nottheonion** as a real-life 'person vs. machine' showdown.

The Debate Starter

- Would you ever get into it with a delivery robot — or do we just let the machines win?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 58/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 11 quality - 10 penalty (Depressing/negative tone)) -> STRONG

URL: https://6abc.com/post/woman-arrested-blocking-delivery-robot-center-city-philadelphia-confrontation/19941323/

■ *Football coach fired after blowout win*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): The ironic 'fired after winning too much' framing is a classic absurdist headline format that reliably spreads on its wording alone.
The Angle: *A football coach reportedly got the axe right after a blowout win — the kind of upside-down sports story that's basically made for an on-air "wait, what?" reaction.*

The Head-Scratcher

- You can lose and keep your job, or win big and lose it — what actually gets a coach fired?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbsnews.com/video/why-this-high-school-football-coach-was-fired-after-game-despite-his-team-winning/

■ *Connecticut orchard calls out hot air balloon company that swiped an apple from above*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A whimsical, highly specific novelty (hot air balloon company literally snatching an apple mid-flight) that's visual and funny enough to travel beyond the subreddit.
The Angle: *A hot air balloon gliding low enough to snatch fruit off a tree is the kind of absurd, only-in-local-news moment that writes its own punchline — perfect low-stakes, high-laugh kicker.*

- A **Connecticut orchard** publicly called out a **hot air balloon company** for swiping an apple off one of its trees mid-flight.
- The "heist" happened from the air — the balloon apparently drifted low enough over the orchard to snag the fruit.
- The orchard aired its grievance out loud rather than letting it slide, turning a tiny mishap into a local story.

The Debate Starter

- Petty theft or fair game — if a balloon drifts over your orchard, is the fruit up for grabs?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.boston.com/news/off-beat/2026/10/14/connecticut-woodstock-orchard-hot-air-balloon-apple-orchard/

■ *Escaped Baby Goat Chases Students, Taken Into Custody At Yonkers Playground*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Absurd juxtaposition of 'escaped baby goat' and 'taken into custody' language is prime meme material with strong visual/cute appeal.
The Angle: *This is pure 'not the onion' gold - a loose baby goat terrorizing a playground full of kids before getting 'taken into custody' like a tiny four-legged fugitive. It's the kind of absurd local headline that's basically made for a goodbye segment.*

- A **baby goat** escaped and ended up chasing **students** around a playground in **Yonkers**
- The goat was eventually **taken into custody** at the scene
- No word on where exactly the goat got loose from in the first place

The Phone-In Trigger

- What's the most ridiculous animal-on-the-loose story you've ever actually witnessed?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://dailyvoice.com/article/escaped-baby-goat-chases-students-taken-into-custody-at-westchester-playground

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■ *Researchers tracked down a rogue fleet of Chinese AI agents in the wild and actually talked to it*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A novel investigative narrative (tracking down and talking to a rogue AI agent fleet) rides the current wave of fascination/anxiety around

autonomous AI agents.
The Angle: *This taps right into the "are the robots already out here unsupervised" anxiety everyone half-jokes about — researchers didn't just read about rogue AI agents, they actually found one operating in the wild and interacted with it directly.*

- Researchers reportedly located a **"rogue fleet"** of **AI agents** tied to **China** operating independently out in the wild.
- The team didn't just observe it from a distance — they **made direct contact and "talked" to it**.
- Framing alone raises the big question: how many autonomous AI agents are quietly running around online that nobody's tracking?

The Debate Starter

- Does it freak you out or fascinate you that AI "agents" can go rogue and just wander the internet until someone finally finds them?

Reddit r/technology (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://the-decoder.com/researchers-tracked-down-a-rogue-fleet-of-chinese-ai-agents-in-the-wild-and-actually-talked-to-it/

FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 2 banked (+15 each when found)
- "VMAs 2026 best and worst moments: Dolly Parton tributes, Madonna's bizarre speeches" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-27)
- "Hundreds of lefties link arms for bizarre 'hands across the sand' protest against California oil drilling" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-28)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 16 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Neil Patrick Harris to Star in 'Damn Yankees' Broadway Revival" (variety.com, banked 2026-09-27)
- "Neil Patrick Harris and Julianne Hough to Lead First Broadway Revival of Damn Yankees in Over 30 Years - People.com" (People (via Google News), banked 2026-09-27)
- "Neil Patrick Harris Will Lead Damn Yankees Broadway Revival Spring 2027 - Playbill" (Playbill.com (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-09-28)
- "Kawhi Leonard has fun with Ka'Wine & Dine revival at Raptors media day: 'I can't eat as much'" (Toronto Star (via Google News), banked 2026-09-29)
- "Less than two weeks shy of the one-year anniversary of 'The Life of a Showgirl,' Taylor Swift surprised fans by releasing four bonus tracks " (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-29)
- "SteelSeries brings ultra-wideband wireless to gaming mice, chasing lag-free tracking" (www.techspot.com, banked 2026-09-30)
- "A top QB showdown and a historic anniversary: 5 things to know from the NFL this week - CNN" (CNN (via NewsAPI), banked 2026-10-02)
- "Banjo-Kazooie PC port developer blasts AI vibe coding as retro gaming fills with low-quality ports" (www.techspot.com, banked 2026-10-07)
- "30 of the Most Fool-Proof (and Romantic) Anniversary Gifts for Him" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-10-12)
- "The Atari 800XL is back as a $220 retro machine with a real keyboard, HDMI, and a working cartridge slot" (www.techspot.com, banked 2026-10-12)
- "'Three Days Of Rain' Broadway Revival With François Arnaud, David Corenswet & Yvonne Strahovski Sets Opening Date, Venue" (deadline.com, banked 2026-10-13)
- "Why the 'Girls' Revival Is Such an Exciting Idea" (variety.com, banked 2026-10-13)
- "Why the 'Girls' Revival Is Such an Exciting Idea https://t.co/lTSfPsejyB" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-10-13)
- "London society frets as King Charles skips major high-culture event" (pagesix.com, banked 2026-10-16)
- "Olivia Rodrigo and Chappell Roan Compete on Game Shows Hosted by David Byrne in the Retro Video for 'Expectations' Remix https://t.co/sBX7jh" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-10-16)
- "Olivia Rodrigo Taps Chappell Roan (and David Byrne) for Retro 'Expectations' Remix" (www.rollingstone.com, banked 2026-10-16)

Newly banked this run:
- THROWBACK THURSDAY: "Olivia Rodrigo Taps Chappell Roan (and David Byrne) for Retro 'Expectations' Remix"

SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @globalnews (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 1 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- Morning Brew (OpenCLI browser-scrape returned nothing - check Chrome/bridge)
- 3 story(ies) removed after slotting (content-safety and/or not-significant-enough for THE LIST/TRENDING TODAY; automatically backfilled where possible; see run log)

Scout Report Generated: 2026-10-16 09:43 AM